



Milena Vásquez-Amézquita

ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR

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📧 Milena-Vasquez-Amezquita | 🏠 grupo-codec.netlify.app/author/milena-vasquez-amezquita/

I am a researcher primarily interested in the neurocognitive bases of human affect and sexuality.

About me

Psychologist, MSc in Basic and Applied Neurosciences, and PhD in Neurosciences. I am a researcher in cognitive neuroscience applied to human sexual behavior. My research integrates cognitive neuroscience, evolutionary psychology, and public health to understand how the brain processes sexually relevant information and how these mechanisms shape sexual attraction, mate preferences, sexual response, and sexual behavior. Using experimental methods—particularly eye tracking—I investigate both normative and atypical sexual interests, with the goal of advancing basic science and informing evidence-based strategies for the prevention of child sexual abuse and exploitation.

I am an Associate Professor at the [Faculty of Psychology](#) at [Universidad El Bosque](#) and an active associate researcher within the [CODEC: Cognitive and Behavioural Sciences](#) Research Group (classified **A1** by MinCiencias). I lead the [SexCog: Sexuality and Affectivity from a Neurocognitive Perspective](#) research hotbed and have led and co-led internally and externally funded research projects using experimental approaches in cognitive neuroscience. I completed a postdoctoral fellowship at [Universidad de la Costa](#), funded by [MinCiencias](#).

Over the past 15 years, I have combined research and university teaching, contributing to undergraduate and graduate education in the neurobiological and cognitive bases of human behavior while supervising undergraduate, master's, and doctoral research projects.



Skills

Programming	R (Basic, data analysis and graph generation)
Quantitative Research	Observational-correlational studies, Simple and Mixed general linear models
Recording techniques	Eye tracking (mainly), other basic HRV, EEG
Software	RStudio, Tobii Pro Lab, Qualtrics, Psychomorph, WebmorphR, Mendeley and Zotero
Languages	English/Spanish (native)

Education

Universidad de Valencia	Valencia, España
PHD - NEUROSCIENCES	2018
Universidad de Valencia	Valencia, España
MASTER'S DEGREE IN BASIC AND APPLIED NEUROSCIENCES	2012
Universidad Católica de Colombia	Bogotá, Colombia
PSYCHOLOGY	2007

Research Experience

Universidad El Bosque	Bogotá, Colombia
ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR	Jan. 2020 - Present
Universidad de la Costa	Barranquilla, Colombia
VISITING PROFESSOR	Dec.2023 - Dec. 2024
Universidad Internacional de Valencia	Valencia, España
COLLABORATING PROFESSOR	Oct.2023 - Present

Professional Experience

For a full list, and a description of responsibilities, please check my [academic CV](#).

ONG RedPapaz

EXTERNAL SCIENTIFIC CONSULTANT

Bogotá, Colombia

Sep. - Oct. 2022

Protect Children

INTERNATIONAL SCIENTIFIC CONSULTANT

Helsinki, Finlandia

Jul. - Aug. 2021

Grants

Universidad El Bosque

XV XV INTERNAL CALL FOR FINANCING RESEARCH AND TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION PROJECTS EL BOSQUE UNIVERSITY, 2025

Bogota, Colombia

Feb. 2026 - Present

- Project: Evolutionary functions of infant-directed speech: Impact on attention, auditory preferences, and early linguistic and musical development
- Role: Co-researcher
- COP\$635.000.000

Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council

PARTNERSHIP ENGAGE GRANTS, 2024

Halifax, Canada

Dic. 2024 - Dic. 2025

- Project: A Partnership for the Prevention of Sexual Exploitation of Children in Travel and Tourism in Colombia
- Role: Co-researcher
- CAD\$25.000

Universidad El Bosque

IX INTERNAL CALL FOR FINANCING RESEARCH AND TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION PROJECTS EL BOSQUE UNIVERSITY, 2024

Bogota, Colombia

Jan. 2024 - Jan. 2026

- Project: Effect of real and simulated resource control on androphilic women's preferences for masculinity in men's faces: an experimental study using eye-tracking
- Role: Principal Researcher
- COP\$90.000.000

Minciencias

POSTDOCTORAL RESEARCH STAYS - CALL 935-2023 - ORCHIDS PROGRAM. WOMEN IN SCIENCE: AGENTS FOR PEACE: AGENTS FOR PEACE 2023

Barranquilla, Colombia

Dic. 2023 - Jan. 2025

- Project: Effect of resource availability on women's preferences for masculinity faces in interaction with hormonal, cognitive, and socio-contextual factors such as actual resource scarcity and exposure to violence: an experimental study using eye-tracking
- COP\$356.040.884

Minciencias

CALL FOR POSTDOCTORAL FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM IN SNCTEI ENTITIES 2019

Barranquilla, Colombia

Jan. 2021 - Jan. 2022

- Project: Feasibility of new interventions to improve the implementation of sexual and reproductive health programs in Colombia.
- COP\$192.000.000

Minciencias

CALL FOR THE STRENGTHENING OF PROJECTS IN EXECUTION OF CTEI IN HEALTH SCIENCES WITH YOUNG TALENT AND REGIONAL IMPACT 2020

Bogota, Colombia

Jan. 2021 - Jan. 2022

- Project: Attentional biases and their relationship with heart rate variability as predictors of emotional state in people without affective disorders in the city of Bogotá.
- Role: Principal Researcher
- COP\$76.000.000

Universidad El Bosque

IX INTERNAL CALL FOR FINANCING RESEARCH AND TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION PROJECTS EL BOSQUE UNIVERSITY, 2017

Bogota, Colombia

Jan. 2018 - Dic. 2021

- Project: Perceivable signs of physical and mental health in faces, voices and body odors, and their relationship to hormone levels
- Role: Co-researcher
- COP\$136.586.537

Universidad El Bosque

VII INTERNAL CALL FOR FINANCING RESEARCH AND TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION PROJECTS EL BOSQUE UNIVERSITY, 2015

Bogota, Colombia

Jan. 2016 - Dic. 2019

- Project: Differences in the pattern of eye tracking to sexually preferred stimuli in men convicted of sexual offenses and the general population
- Role: Principal Researcher
- COP\$80.000.000

- Project: Mediating factors of Cognitive Reserve and its relationship with the neuropsychological profile of the older adult in the process of normal aging
- Role: Principal Researcher
- COP\$20.000.000

Scholarships, Awards and Honors

Universidad El Bosque

Bogotá, Colombia

X EXCELLENCE AWARDS

Dic. 2023

- COP\$10.000.000

Universidad El Bosque

Bogotá, Colombia

VIII EXCELLENCE AWARDS

Dic. 2019

- COP\$5.000.000

Universidad El Bosque

Bogotá, Colombia

VII EXCELLENCE AWARDS

Dic. 2018

- COP\$2.500.000

Universidad de Valencia

Valencia, España

CUM LAUDE MENTION

Sep. 2018

- PhD Thesis in Neurosciences

Universidad de Valencia

Valencia, España

LUISA CARDONA SCHOLARSHIP

Nov.2011 - Nov.2012

- Fee exemption for the Official Master's Degree

Universidad Católica de Colombia

Bogotá, Colombia

HONORARY DEGREE

Sep. 2007

- Improved performance among undergraduate psychology students

Universidad Católica de Colombia

Bogotá, Colombia

MENTION FOR EXCELLENCE

Mar.2007

- Mention postgraduate scholarship for obtaining the highest score among the psychology students of the faculty and 3rd place nationally in the 2006 version of the Quality Examination for Higher Education in Colombia (ECAES).

Selected Publications

9 *h-index* 19 *g-index* 9 *i10-index* 26 Publications 542 Citations

For a full list, please check the publications section on my [academic CV](#).

Castellanos-Chacón, A., Arias-Otero, D., Uribe-Jaramillo, V., Leongómez, J. D., & **Vásquez-Amézquita, M.** (2026). Effects of stimulus emotional content on gaze pattern: An eye-tracking study. *PLOS One*, 21(1), e0341261. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0341261>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Castellanos-Chacón, A., Medina-Sarmiento, W., Cepeda, V., Martínez-González, M. B., & Leongómez, J. D. (2025). Resource availability and experiences of partner violence shape facial masculinity preferences in Colombian women. *Evolution and Human Behavior*, 46(4), 106707. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.evolhumbehav.2025.106707>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Martínez-González, M. B., Chivers, M. L., & Leongómez, J. D. (2025). Does Trait Sexual Desire Predict Subjective Sexual Response to Erotic Stimuli? Effects of Participant Gender, Stimulus Gender, and Relationship Status Among Cisgender Heterosexual Women and Men. *Archives of Sexual Behavior*, 54, 4209–4223. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10508-025-03298-w>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Cepeda, V., Roa, E., Torres, J. S., Maldonado-Avenidaño, N., Martínez-González, M. B., & Leongómez, J. D. (2025). Sexual modes questionnaire (SMQ): Spanish translation, adaptation, and preliminary evidence of psychometric properties in a Colombian sample. *Sexual and Relationship Therapy*, 1–25. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14681994.2025.2507109>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Leongómez, J. D., Salvador, A., & Seto, M. C. (2023). What can the eyes tell us about atypical sexual preferences as a function of sex and age? Linking eye movements with child-related chronophilias. *Forensic Sciences Research*, 8(1)1–11. <https://doi.org/10.1093/fsr/owad009>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Salvador, A., & Leongómez, J. D. (2021). Existen diferencias en la ratio 2D:4D entre delincuentes sexuales y no sexuales, y hombres no delincuentes? Un estudio en una muestra colombiana. *Interdisciplinaria. Revista de Psicología y Ciencias Afines*, 39(1). <https://doi.org/10.16888/interd.2022.39.1.8>

- Jones, B. C., DeBruine, L. M., Flake, J. K., Liuzza, M. T., Antfolk, J., Arinze, N. C., Ndukaihe, I. L. G., Bloxsom, N. G., Lewis, S. C., Foroni, F., Willis, M. L., Cubillas, C. P., Vadillo, M. A., Turiegano, E., Gilead, M., Simchon, A., Saribay, S. A., Owsley, N. C., Jang, C. ..., **Vásquez-Amézquita, M.**, ..., Coles, N. A. (2021). To which world regions does the valence–dominance model of social perception apply? *Nature Human Behaviour*, 5(1) 159–169. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-020-01007-2>
- Vásquez-Amézquita, M.**, Leongómez, J. D., Seto, M. C., Bonilla, F. M., Rodríguez-Padilla, A., & Salvador, A. (2018). No relation between digit ratio (2D:4D) and visual attention patterns to sexually preferred and non-preferred stimuli. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 120, 151–158. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2017.08.022>
- Vásquez-Amézquita, M.**, Leongómez, J. D., Seto, M. C., Bonilla, M., Rodríguez-Padilla, A., & Salvador, A. (2019). Visual Attention Patterns Differ in Gynephilic and Androphilic Men and Women Depending on Age and Gender of Targets. *The Journal of Sex Research*, 56(1), 85–101. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00224499.2017.1372353>
- Vásquez-Amézquita, M.**, Leongómez, J. D., Seto, M. C., & Salvador, A. (2019). Differences in Visual Attention Patterns to Sexually Mature and Immature Stimuli Between Heterosexual Sexual Offenders, Nonsexual Offenders, and Nonoffending Men. *The Journal of Sex Research*, 56 (2), 213–228. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00224499.2018.1511965>

Postgraduate Supervision

For a full list, including undergraduate supervision, please check my [academic CV](#).

Leidy Nathaly Peláez Bernal

MSC IN NEUROPSYCHOLOGY

*Universidad Internacional de
Valencia, España*

2023-2024

Jimena Zanizo Chambi

MSC IN NEUROPSYCHOLOGY

*Universidad Internacional de
Valencia, España*

2023-2024

Liceth Andrea Zaraza Osorio

MSC IN NEUROPSYCHOLOGY

*Universidad Internacional de
Valencia, España*

2023-2024